supposed to get hectic. I always wanted to play World Cup games, irrespective of how little sleep I got or how busy I was kept between games.

Perhaps some of the team's problems in the 2003 Word Cup stemmed from Shaun Pollock. Polly was one helluva cricketer – one of the best this country has ever had – but he wasn't a natural leader. Certainly not in the way Hansie had been. But to be fair to Shaun, it could not have been easy taking over from Hansie, given the former captain's powerful personality *and* the mess he'd left behind. Polly always led by example on the pitch, but he was a little too distant from his teammates.

Polly was also one for the disciplinarian approach. He was like a teacher in a lot of ways, especially the way he spoke at team meetings. He made me think of school a lot, and I never did very well at school. For Polly, it was all about what happened out in the middle – the actual cricket – and not about getting to know his teammates off the field. I guess he was very professional, but maybe too much so, as he never really came out and partied with us. Polly doesn't drink, but I'd always hoped he would join us socially more often.

Of course it is unfair to lay all the blame at Polly's door, but, fact is, we were not the tight unit we had been under Hansie.

We lost that opening game to the West Indies by three runs – Brian Lara got 116 – which basically set the tone for the rest of our games. One of my personal highlights was smacking 143 off 141 deliveries against New Zealand in a pool game – my third-highest ODI score after making 153 against Bangladesh in 2002, and 175 against the Aussies in 2006's famous 438 game.

Unfortunately, a rain interruption led to a revised target of 226 runs in 39 overs for the Black Caps according to the Duckworth-Lewis method, after we'd posted 306 in our innings. The Kiwi captain, Stephen Fleming, scored 134 after we dropped him when he hadn't got past 20 yet, and we lost the game. We did beat minnows Kenya, Bangladesh and Canada, but so did everyone else, which meant we needed to beat Sri Lanka in our final pool game to go through to the Super Six stage of the tournament. I don't think there's a cricket fan in South Africa who doesn't know what happened next.

What a cock-up.

Batting first at Kingsmead, the Sri Lankans scored 268, after which we seemed to be gunning along nicely. I scored 73, then Mark Boucher came in and was looking strong on 45 … and then the rain came bucketing down.